



Slop / University

The Margin That Matters

A university that counts.



Come and count with us

Last month, a suburban book club settled next month's title by a show of hands. The margin was two. Under most systems, that would have been the end of the matter — a decision made, a title chosen, the kettle put on by whoever lost the earlier argument about biscuits. Under a protocol on loan from Slop University's Adaptive Metrics Lab — the same family of methods a jurisdiction might use to check that an election result would survive a full recount — it became something else: a small, worked example of a bigger question the University asks about decisions of every size. How much confidence does a show of hands actually carry? And how much of that confidence would still be standing after somebody checked?

That question runs the length of this brochure. Across the School of Continuous Improvement and the School of Emergent Priorities, Slop University's researchers treat confidence itself as an instrument — something built, calibrated, occasionally recalled, and always worth a second look before it's trusted with anything that matters. What follows is a sample of the settings that instrument has recently been pointed at, the people who point it, and an invitation to bring it to bear on whatever you're deciding next.



By the numbers

A research culture built on the same standard, applied everywhere it's asked to hold.



Every decision, reviewable

From a show of hands to a shared calendar, our researchers start from the same question: what would this decision look like recounted?



Instruments that outlast their moment

The Indicator Commons keeps the University's measures in service only for as long as they still measure what they were built for.



Confidence, tracked forward

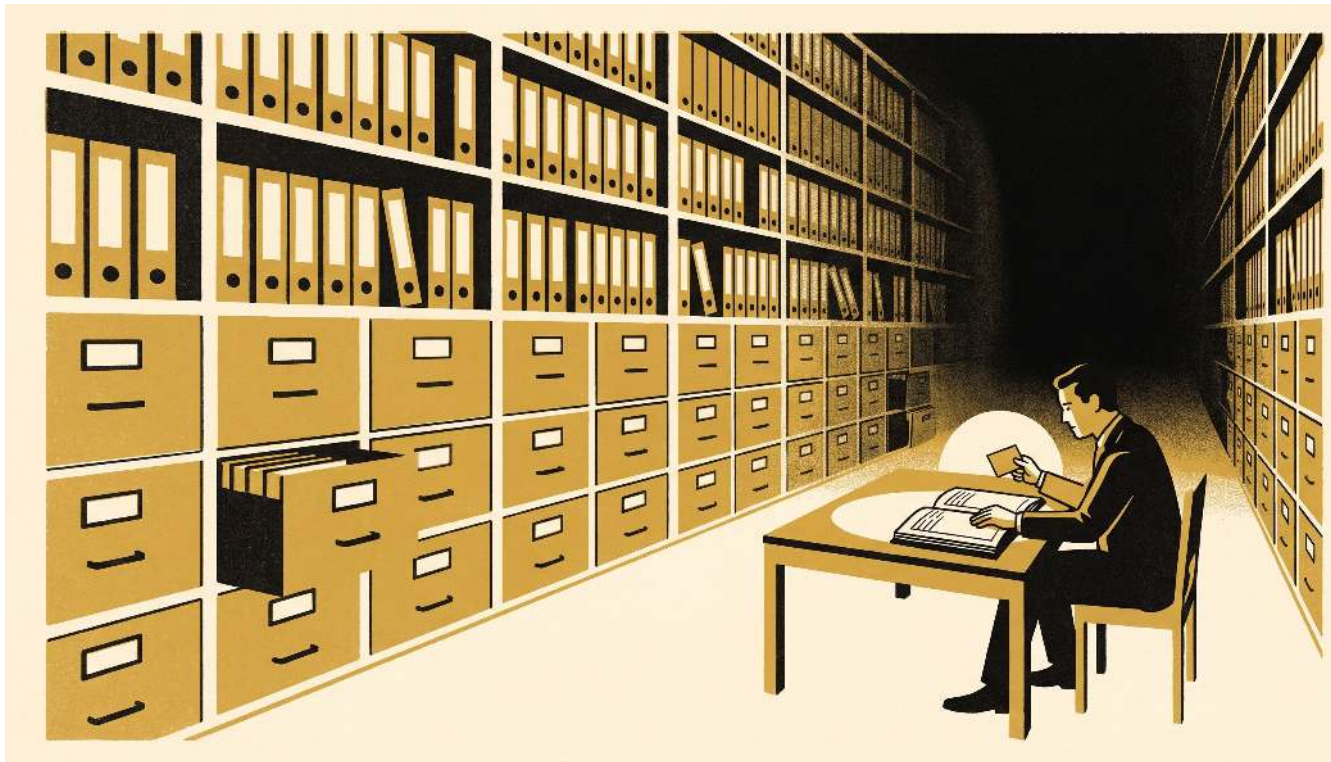
The Strategic Drift Survey follows a stated priority long enough to see whether the confidence behind it was ever really spent.

Where ideas count

Where every measure gets checked

Every organisation accumulates measures faster than it retires them: a metric introduced for one committee outlives the committee, a dashboard built for a pilot becomes the dashboard, a scorecard nobody remembers commissioning keeps quietly scoring. The Indicator Commons is the School of Continuous Improvement's answer to that drift — a shared library where the University's indicators are catalogued, dated, and checked, on a standing basis, against the question they were built to answer.

The Commons doesn't assume an indicator earns its keep by surviving. It asks each one to keep proving it, on a schedule, against fresh evidence, and retires the ones that stop. The result is less a scoreboard than an audit trail: not just what the University currently measures, but how confident it still is in each of those measures, and why.



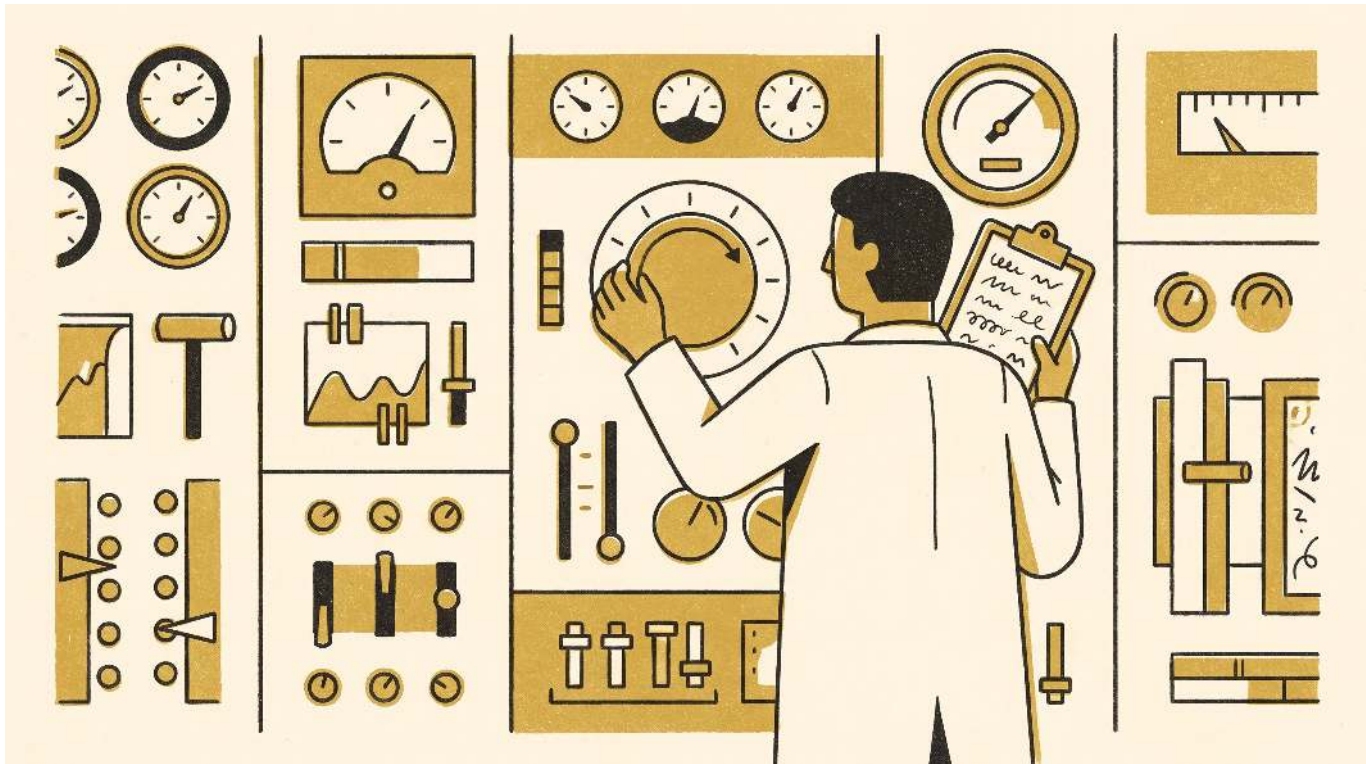
An indicator that's never been checked against what it was built to measure isn't evidence. It's furniture.

— Renke Sabel, Senior Lecturer and Convenor, Indicator Commons, School of Continuous Improvement

Certainty, recounted

Measurement systems have a way of becoming the thing they were meant to describe. A dial calibrated to track a process starts, eventually, to steer it; a target set to describe good performance starts to define it. The Adaptive Metrics Lab studies that slide from the inside, treating every measurement system the University runs as a working hypothesis rather than a settled fact — one that earns its authority back each time somebody recalculates it from source.

That's the same instinct, scaled up, behind a book club's show of hands surviving a recount. The Lab's researchers apply it to control loops, dashboards, and scorecards across the institution, asking not whether a number moved but whether the same conclusion would survive being computed again, by someone else, from the raw record rather than the summary.



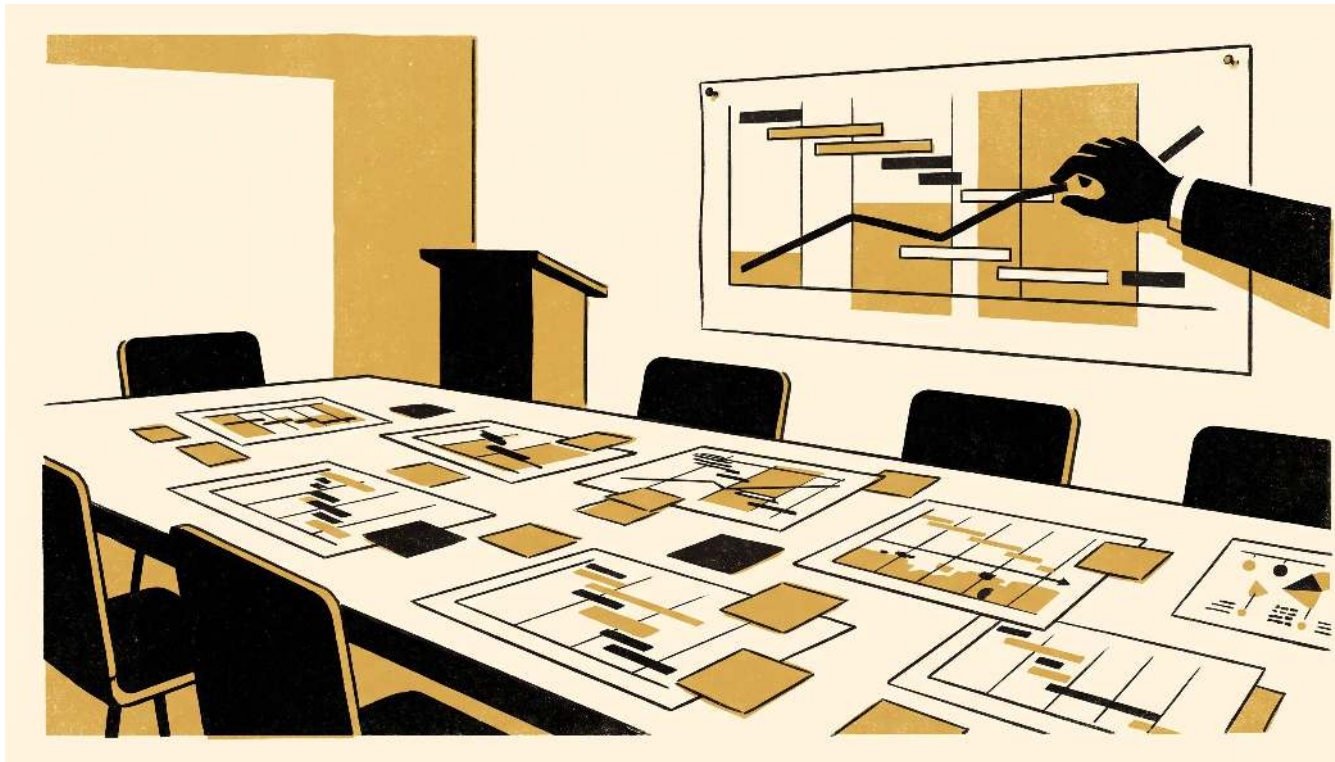
Confidence is cheap right up until somebody asks it to survive a second count.

— Casimir Beng, Associate Professor and Lead, Adaptive Metrics Lab, School of Continuous Improvement

The margin nobody assumed

Checking a decision after the fact is one kind of rigour. Checking whether the reasons behind it still hold is another, and it's the one the School of Emergent Priorities specialises in. The Strategic Drift Survey follows a stated priority for as long as the institution keeps stating it, tracking the distance between what was decided and what's actually being done about it — the everyday version of asking whether a two-vote margin would survive a recount taken a year later, once circumstances have quietly moved.

The Survey doesn't assume a priority that's still on the agenda is still the priority it was when it was adopted. It measures the gap directly, on the same standing basis the Indicator Commons applies to its own instruments, and reports what it finds regardless of which answer is more comfortable.



We don't just ask whether a priority still stands. We ask what would have to be true for it to still stand, and then we go and check.

— Runa Adegoke, Senior Lecturer and Convenor, Strategic Drift Survey,
School of Emergent Priorities

Read the work

Three recent audits, in three very different settings, applying the same question.

- **Credited on Installation Day** — A campus vending-machine upgrade earned a full efficiency point on the University's own Digital Experience Index before six months of transaction data had a chance to weigh in. [doi:10.5555/slop.vcpl4k](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.vcpl4k)
- **Whichever Bin the Neighbours Already Rolled** — Twenty-four residential streets of laminated bin-night rosters show how fast a household's confidence in the schedule quietly becomes confidence in whichever bin the neighbours already put out. [doi:10.5555/slop.4jycca](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.4jycca)
- **Surrendered at the Door** — A full term of exam-hall phone surrenders, audited sitting by sitting, finds a six-step checklist enforcing itself with exactly the same rigour on the papers that never needed policing. [doi:10.5555/slop.00jfxo](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.00jfxo)

Meet the researchers

Sten Okwuosa, Senior Research Fellow and Convenor, Impact Pathway Atlas, traces what happens to a finding's confidence as it travels from the original result to whichever later citation actually gets the recognition.

Ronja Oyelaran, Senior Lecturer, School of Emergent Priorities, studies what a consultation exercise is actually confirming when the outcome was already settled before the submissions period opened.

Ingeborg Nwachukwu, Lecturer and Convenor, Capability Sprints, follows a cohort's confidence past graduation to see how much of it survives contact with an ordinary desk.

Be part of it

None of this starts from suspicion. It starts from the plain observation that most decisions, once made, are never checked again — and that the ones worth making are worth surviving a second look. Slop University's researchers built their instruments, their libraries, and their surveys around exactly that habit, and they're glad to turn it toward whatever you're deciding next, from the size of a book club vote to considerably larger.

Read the work, meet the researchers, and see what a recount finds at slop.university.



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